

Where There is NO WILL

For a ban to be effective, determination has to be matched by reliable intelligence and concerted action

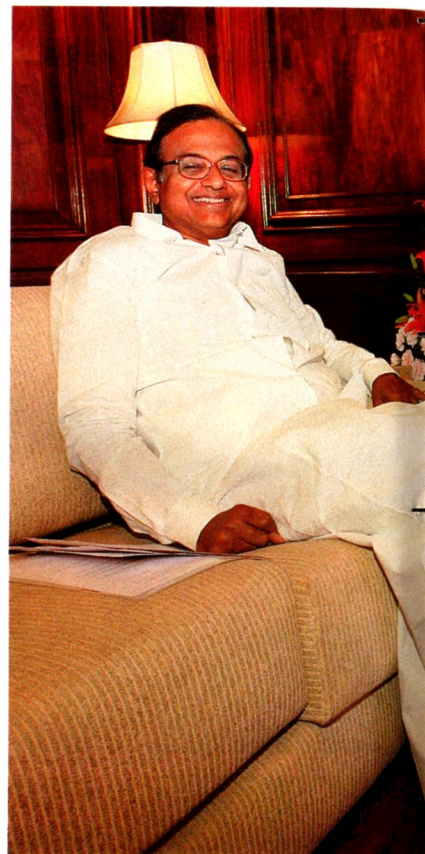
| By Bhavna Vij-Aurora |

Left wing extremism is the biggest security threat to the country. We cannot sleep in peace until this scourge is firmly dealt with."—Prime Minister Manmohan Singh.

Five years and several hundred lives after the prime minister told a chief ministers' conclave to buck up to face the challenge from Left ultras, Home Minister P. Chidambaram last week declared the CPI (Maoist) a terrorist organisation and announced the Government's decision to ban it. The move was more to prove a political point than to achieve real tactical gain. The Maoists had been holding Lalgarh to ransom and the CPI(M)-led West Bengal Government appeared to be dithering in acting against them. In a meeting with West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya last weekend, Chidambaram had requested him to declare the outfit as an unlawful association as had been done by other Naxal-affected states. The move expectedly met with resistance from the West Bengal Government and senior leaders of the Left parties, who said that the Maoists should be dealt with politically. Treating them as terrorists would only worsen the situation, they argued. CPI(M) leader Sitaram Yechury

called on Chidambaram to protest the ban while party General Secretary Prakash Karat wanted the Government to use persuasive tactics. They claimed that proscribing an organisation never helped, clearly forgetting that the Left and its allies had on several occasions in the past demanded that right wing outfits including the RSS, VHP, Shiv Sena and Bajrang Dal be banned.

Shortly after the Maoists started a 48-hour general strike in the Lalgarh belt of West Bengal and adjoining Jharkhand, Bihar, Chhattisgarh and Orissa, the Government clamped down, declaring them terrorists under the Unlawful Activities Prevention Act (UAPA). The ban puts the ultras in the same league as 34 other organisations including the Al-Qaida, Jaish-e-Mohammad (JEM), Lashkar-e-Toiba (LET), Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE), United Liberation Front of Assam (ULFA) and Students' Islamic



Movement of India (SIMI). The Centre's ban forced the West Bengal Government to act, its reluctance notwithstanding. The state was now legally bound to take action against the organisation, which it did by arresting Maoists' spokesman Gour Chakraborty.

However, unwilling to yield any political mileage, Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya said that the actual implementation of the ban remained the prerogative of his Government which also refused to declare it as an unlawful association under the Criminal



AFTER HIS ARREST, MAOIST SPOKESMAN CHAKRABORTY SAID THEY WERE READY TO TALK WITH THE CENTRE.